

Θεμίστιος ὁ Εὐφραδής

Themistius the Philosopher and the Paraphrases of Aristotle

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Period: Ὀψιμαρχαία Late Antique

Dialect: Ἀττικίζουσα Atticizing

Domain: Φιλοσοφία Philosophy

Format: Λόγος Oration

Affiliation: Eclectic

Themistius was a philosopher, rhetorician, and statesman of the 4th century CE. He was born around 317 CE in Paphlagonia and died around 388 CE. His career was centered in Constantinople, where he served as a senator and political advisor under a series of Roman emperors, including Constantius II, Julian, and Theodosius I. Although a pagan, Themistius maintained his position in a Christian imperial court by promoting religious tolerance and arguing that classical philosophy supported good governance. He was appointed as a royal tutor and was known by the epithet "Euphrades," meaning "eloquent."

His surviving works include two main types. First are his orations: 34 ceremonial speeches delivered at court that blend praise of the emperor with philosophical ideas. Second are his paraphrases of Aristotle's works, which were not strict commentaries but clear explanatory summaries designed for students. These paraphrases became very influential.

Modern scholars see Themistius as a pivotal figure. He helped transmit and simplify Aristotelian philosophy during an era when Neoplatonic thought was more dominant, making it accessible for later Byzantine and Arabic traditions. His speeches also provide valuable historical insight into the political culture and ideals of leadership in the late Roman Empire. He is often interpreted as embodying the ideal of a "philosopher in the city," actively using philosophy to engage with public life and imperial rule.

Works (41)

- Ὑπατικός εἰς τὸν αὐτοκράτορα Ἰοβιανόν · Consular to Emperor Jovian · 30 passages
- Δεκητηρικός ἢ περὶ τῶν πρεπόντων λόγων τῷ βασιλεῖ · Deceteric or-Appropriate Speeches to the King · 43 passages
- Ἡ ἐπὶ τῷ λόγῳ διάλεξις · Discourse-the Word · 10 passages
- Πρεσβευτικός εἰς Θεοδοσίον αὐτοκράτορα · Embassy to Emperor Theodosius · 14 passages
- Πρεσβευτικός ὑπὲρ Κωνσταντινουπόλεως ῥηθεὶς ἐν · Embassy-Behalf of Constantinople Delivered in Rome · 30 passages
- Ἐπιτάφιος ἐπὶ τῷ πατρί · Epitaph-the Father · 28 passages
- Ἐρωτικός ἢ περὶ κάλλους βασιλικοῦ · Erotic or-Royal Beauty · 70 passages
- Προτρεπτικός Νικομηδεῦσιν εἰς φιλοσοφίαν · Exhortation to Nicomedians-Philosophy · 34 passages
- Προτρεπτικός Οὐαλεντινιανῷ νέῳ · Exhortation to Young Valentinian · 33 passages
- Μετριοπαθής ἢ φιλότεκνος · Moderate or Fond of Children · 33 passages

- [Περὶ τῆς Ἀριστοτέλους Φυσικῆς · On Aristotle's Physics, Paraphrase](#) · 237 passages
- [Περὶ φιλίας · On Friendship](#) · 69 passages
- [Περὶ τοῦ μὴ δεῖν τοῖς τόποις ἀλλὰ τοῖς ἀνδράσι · On Not Paying Attention to Places but to Men](#) · 33 passages
- [Περὶ φιланθρωπίας ἢ Κωνσταντίου · On Philanthropy or Constantius](#) · 65 passages
- [Περὶ φρονήσεως · On Prudence](#) · 5 passages
- [〈Υπὲρ τοῦ λέγειν ἢ πῶς τῷ φιλοσόφῳ λεκτέον〉 · On Speaking or How the Philosopher Should Speak](#) · 64 passages
- [Περὶ τῆς τοῦ βασιλέως φιληκοῖας · On the King's Love of Praise](#) · 31 passages
- [〈Περὶ τῶν ὀνομάτων τοῦ βασιλέως καὶ τοῦ ὑπάτου〉 · On the Names of the King and the Consul](#) · 12 passages
- [Ἐπὶ τῇ χειροτονίᾳ τῆς πολιαρχίας · On the Ordination of the Polity](#) · 12 passages
- [Ἐπὶ τῆς εἰρήνης Οὐάλεντι · On the Peace of Valens](#) · 50 passages
- [Ἐπὶ τῇ φιλανθρωπίᾳ τοῦ αὐτοκράτορος Θεοδοσίου · On the Philanthropy of Emperor Theodosius](#) · 31 passages
- [Περὶ προεδρίας εἰς τὴν σύγκλητον · On the Presidency in the Senate](#) · 15 passages
- [Περὶ ψυχῆς · On the Soul](#) · 4 passages
- [Περὶ τῶν ἡτυχηκότων ἐπὶ Οὐάλεντος · On Those Who Failed Under Valens](#) · 66 passages
- [Εἰς Κωνσταντίον τὸν αὐτοκράτορα, ὅτι μάλιστα · Oration to Emperor Constantius on the Philosopher King](#) · 56 passages
- [Σχόλια εἰς τὰ Ἀριστοτέλους περὶ ψυχῆς · Paraphrase of On the Soul](#) · 127 passages
- [Σχόλια εἰς τὰ Παρὰ Φυσικά · Paraphrase of Parva Naturalia](#) · 45 passages
- [Παράφρασις τῶν Ἀναλυτικῶν Ὑστέρων · Paraphrase Of Posterior Analytics](#) · 67 passages
- [Πενταετηρικός · Penteteric](#) · 72 passages
- [Φιλάδελφοι ἢ περὶ φιλανθρωπίας · Philadelphians or-Philanthropy](#) · 50 passages
- [〈Φ〉 ἰλόπολις · Philopolis](#) · 1 passages
- [Σοφιστής · Sophist](#) · 58 passages
- [Χαριστήριος τῷ αὐτοκράτορι ὑπὲρ τῆς εἰρήνης καὶ · Thanksgiving to the Emperor for the Peace and Consulship of General Saturninus](#) · 53 passages
- [Ἡ φερομένη εἰς τὸν Ἀριστοτέλους Ἀναλυτικῶν · Themistius's Commentary on Aristotle's Prior Analytics, Book I](#) · 165 passages
- [Θέσις εἰ γεωργητέον · Thesis-Whether to Farm](#) · 15 passages
- [Εἰς τὸν αὐτοκράτορα Κωνσταντίον · To Emperor Constantius](#) · 49 passages
- [Πρὸς τὸν ἀξιώσαντα λέγειν ἐκ τοῦ παραχρῆμα · To the One Who Demanded Immediate Speech](#) · 2 passages
- [Εἰς Θεοδοσίον· τίς ἡ βασιλικωτάτη τῶν ἀρετῶν · To Theodosius, Which is the Most Royal of Virtues](#) · 55 passages
- [Πρὸς τοὺς αἰτιασαμένους ἐπὶ τῷ δέξασθαι τὴν ἀρχήν · To Those Accusing-Accepting the Office](#) · 31 passages
- [Πρὸς τοὺς οὐκ ὀρθῶς ἐξηγουμένους τὸν σοφιστὴν · To Those Not Correctly Interpreting the Sophist](#) · 18 passages
- [Βασανιστής ἢ φιλόσοφος · Tormentor or Philosopher](#) · 72 passages

Other Eclectic Authors

- [Ἀέτιος ὁ Δοξογράφος · Aetius the Doxographer](#) · 2 works
- [Ἀντίοχος ὁ Ἀσκαλώνιος · Antiochus of Ascalon](#) · 1 work
- [Ἰωάννης ὁ Στοβαῖος · John Stobaeus of Stobi](#) · 1 work